



RAVI S. SAHANI

NOT SO TRUE: Baba Gurmeet Ram Rahim

probe.

For the Dera chief, already facing the ire of the Sikh organisations, the CBI bombshell could not have come at a worse time. Going by the seriousness of the charges, CBI is likely to seek his arrest for custodial interrogation when the case comes up for hearing on August 31.

Predictably, the Dera management has been quick to accuse the bureau of implicating the Baba to malign him and the sect. "It's a politically-motivated conspiracy to defame the Dera and we will challenge these insinuations legally" says a Dera functionary. But, the charges have dealt a severe blow to the reputation of the 60-year-old sect which has a substantial following in Punjab, Haryana and Rajasthan.

The Baba's mounting legal troubles have only sharpened the animus between the Dera and the ruling Shiromani Akali Dal—a development fraught with far reaching consequences in Punjab politics. **by Ramesh Vinayak**

SIGNPOSTS

WON: The doubles title of the Challenger Cup by **Rohan Bopanna** and his Pakistani partner Aisam-ul-Haq Qureshi. The duo clinched its third straight ATP doubles title by defeating Michel Kratochvil of Switzerland and Luxembourg's Gilles Muller by 7-6, 6-3.

AWARDED: Ustad Rahim Fahimuddin Khan Dagar with Lifetime Achievement Award by the Delhi Cabinet for his outstanding contribution



to classical music. Dagar is a doyen of Dhrupad style of singing and has dedicated his life to it.

DIED: Veteran All-India Forward Bloc leader and former West Bengal minister, **Kamal Guha**, after a prolonged illness. He was 79.

APPOINTED: Actor **Shabana Azmi** as the president of the International Jury for the inaugural Asia-Pacific Screen Awards to be held in Australia.

Sex, Lies and Godman

CHANDIGARH For the Dera Sacha Sauda followers, August is usually an auspicious month to celebrate their spiritual head Baba Gurmeet Ram Rahim Singh's birthday. But not this year. On August 1, the CBI charged the controversial godman, who would turn 40 on August 15, with three criminal cases relating to two murders and sexual exploitation of sadhvis (women devotees) at the Dera.

He had earlier been in trouble over charges of having imitated Guru Gobind Singh. In a criminal case related with this

issue, the high court has directed him to cooperate with police investigations on grounds of having hurt the religious sentiments of the Sikhs.

The CBI, in its report, has charged the Baba with "hatching conspiracy" of the murders of his one-time follower Ranjit Singh and a Sirsa-based journalist Ram Chander Chattarpati, and for raping two sadhvis. The agency had been investigating the affairs of the Dera for the past four years despite pressure from both legal and political fronts to scuttle the

VIS-A-VIS **NITISH KUMAR** Bihar chief minister **versus** **LALU PRASAD YADAV** Railway minister

“ Instead of travelling on government funds, this money could have been used in flood relief. He is wasting money on aerial surveys. ”



SAURABH SINGH

“ There has been criminal neglect of responsibility. When the state was reeling under floods, the CM was busy touring abroad. ”

EPILOGUE: Instead of squabbling, the two should work together for those affected by floods.